ASKEL VENTURES

# Acquiring boring businesses. Building compounding value.

MICRO PRIVATE EQUITY · NORDIC SMALL BUSINESS ACQUISITIONS

THE OPPORTUNITY

# A wave of succession transitions no one is equipped to handle.

**73,000+**
Finnish entrepreneurs aged 54+

**34,000**
intend to sell to an outside buyer within the decade

**20,000+**
viable businesses at closure risk — no suitable buyer exists

- **The silver tsunami is here.**
  Across the Nordics, essential small businesses are profitable and resilient — but founder-led and approaching succession transition.
- **Structural gap in the market.**
  These businesses are too small for traditional private equity and too operationally demanding for passive investors.
- **Modern tools, untapped.**
  Many lack data visibility, scalable processes, and modern systems. AI and software now create practical efficiency gains in admin, sales, reporting, and operations.
- **Attractive entry multiples.**
  Stable, cash-generative businesses available at 3–4× EBITDA — a pricing dynamic unavailable at scale in any other asset class.

THE MODEL

# We buy, operate, grow, and selectively exit – then reinvest the proceeds.

**SOURCE & ACQUIRE**
3–4× EBITDA entry
debt + equity

→

**APPLY PLAYBOOK**
Systems, AI,
commercial dev

→

**GROW**
Target 3× EBITDA
over 5 years

→

**SELL AT PREMIUM**
6–8× EBITDA
to passive buyers

→

**REDEPLOY**
Fund next acquisition
or return capital

- **Agentic AI sourcing.**
  Our proprietary software system (a.k.a. Steve 🦔) monitors online signals — listing activity, job ads, owner interviews, trade press — to identify businesses approaching succession before they hit the market.

- **We sell when the Askel effect is fully realized**
  — not because investors need liquidity, but because the next euro of value creation happens elsewhere. Portfolio exits fund future acquisitions and create natural investor liquidity.

- **What we mean by boring businesses.**
  Cash-generative SMEs in essential, non-glamorous services — laundromats, cleaning, waste collection, B2B trades. Resilient demand, low disruption risk, 400K–1.5M EUR revenue, 3–4× EBITDA entry. Unglamorous by design.

- **Inspired by the Barbell strategy.**
  Buying boring but profitable businesses, digitalizing them, and building a tech layer on top — stable cash flows on one end, asymmetric upside on the other.

OUR EDGE

# The Askel Effect – a documented playbook for transforming small businesses.

- **Experienced operators, hands-on**
  Askel is founded by serial entrepreneurs who have built and run SMEs themselves. We don't just advise — we take the lead, with boots on the ground and a documented playbook to back it up.

- **Commercial development**
  We kickstart modern sales and marketing — proactive outreach, digital channels, and systematic lead generation — alongside pricing discipline, customer mix optimisation, and revenue quality. Areas previous owners typically left untouched.

- **The Growth Engine**
  Replacing ad-hoc processes and spreadsheet operations with a modern, proven tech stack. A repeatable Growth Engine — documented and improving with every acquisition.

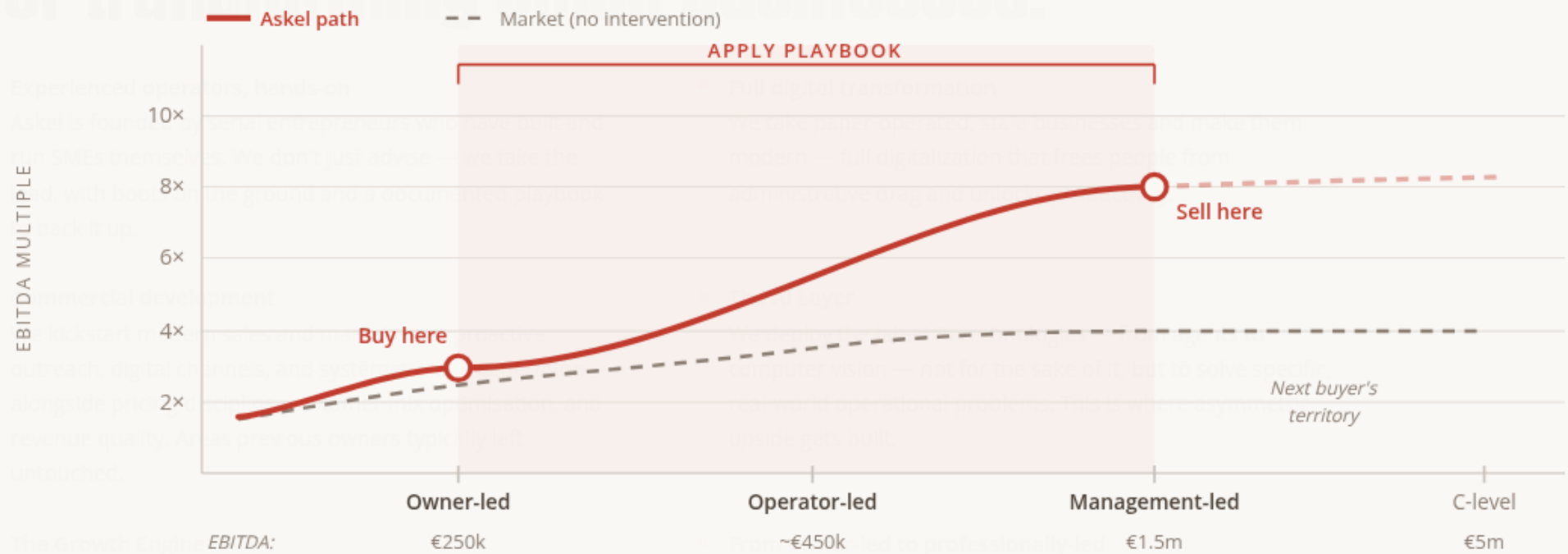
- **Full digital transformation**
  We take paper-operated, stale businesses and make them modern — full digitalization that frees people from administrative drag and unlocks productivity.

- **The AI Layer**
  We deploy the latest AI technologies — from agents to computer vision — not for the sake of it, but to solve specific, real-world operational problems. This is where asymmetric upside gets built.

- **From owner-led to professionally-led**
  We recruit dedicated operators for each business — often replacing the outgoing founder — and build around them: stronger governance, clearer operating cadence, and the systems to scale without founder dependency.

THE ASKEL EFFECT IN NUMBERS

# How boring becomes extraordinary.




EBITDA GROWTH
**€250k → €1.5m**

MULTIPLE EXPANSION
**3-4× → 6-8×**

THE MECHANISM
**De-risk the operation. Grow the business. The market reprices both.**

*Illustrative figures. Actual multiples vary by business, sector, and execution.*

THE TEAM

# Founders with deep tech and business building experience.

## Varia Wahlroos-Kaitila CEO

ACQUISITION & COMMERCIAL VALUE CREATION

Founded 5 companies across agency, SaaS, and venture-backed startups. Built a marketing business from 0 to €2M ARR, sold a company, and led negotiations with banks and institutional partners for the first acquisition.

## Niklas Slotte CRO

DEAL EXECUTION & REVENUE SCALING

Serial entrepreneur with experience building and leading multiple businesses, including scaling an international company to €8M ARR. Brings sharp commercial judgment, team leadership, and hands-on ownership during roll-up execution.

## Mikael Ylinen BOARD

OPERATIONAL DEPTH & INDUSTRIAL UNDERSTANDING

Entrepreneur and long-term board operator with broad end-to-end business understanding. Brings practical experience in production environments, hardware, and the operational realities that determine whether acquisitions hold together.

## Mike Solomon CTO

AI SYSTEMS & SOFTWARE LEVERAGE

PhD in Mathematics, Stanford graduate, and full-stack AI systems builder. Develops the internal software and AI agents that increase sourcing capacity, accelerate diligence, and create operating leverage across the portfolio.

10 COMPANIES FOUNDED | €8M ARR SCALED INTERNATIONALLY | STANFORD · HANKEN ×2 · PHD MATHEMATICS | AI & FULL-STACK SYSTEMS | VC-BACKED + TRADITIONAL BUSINESS EXPERIENCE

THE INVESTMENT

# Equity in Askel Ventures. Raising up to €1M.

INSTRUMENT

**Ordinary shares** in Askel Ventures via private placement. Investors hold the same share class as the founders — no preference stack, no separate share class. We win when you win.

WHAT YOU'RE BUYING

**Layer 1:** Asset value — Melers, our first acquisition.
**Layer 2:** Cash flow from a growing portfolio of profitable businesses.
**Layer 3:** Dedicated hands-on founding team.
**Layer 4:** A proven playbook for sourcing, acquiring, and developing SMEs.
**Layer 5:** Proprietary AI platform — including Steve 🦔, our sourcing agent.

USE OF FUNDS

Next 5 acquisitions to reach efficient compounding scale — the point where portfolio cash flows and exit proceeds create a self-funding flywheel.

FINANCIAL TARGET

Grow portfolio companies **10–20% per year.** Exit at 6–8× EBITDA. Target holdco IRR of 25–35%.

LIQUIDITY

Portfolio exits generate holdco liquidity **starting from year 3.** Secondary transfers available with company consent (ROFR). A strategic acquisition of the holdco provides a full exit for all shareholders.

MINIMUM TICKET

**€100,000.** Closing on a rolling basis.

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Book a conversation →

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